

**GOVERNMENT OF INDIA ACT
1935, ELECTION IN 1937 AND
BENGAL LEGISLATIVE
ASSEMBLY**

ELECTION IN 1937 AND BENGAL LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY

- The British government introduced Government of India Act 1935 giving more autonomy to provincial governments. This act provided formation of legislative Assembly in every Province of India to be elected by people on the basis of adult franchise and separate electorate system.
- Under this act, an election was held in undivided Bengal to form Bengal Legislative Assembly in 1937.
- Total number of seats allocated for different communities and ethnic groups were 250. The major parties that participated in the election are Congress (54 seats) , Muslim league (40), Krishak Praja Party (37) and other independent and minor parties.
- No party got the absolute majority to form government. Krishak Praja Party led by AK Fazlul Hoque formed coalition with Muslim League and A K Fazlul Hoque as Chief Minister formed the government at the invitation of the Governor.
- Among others, Khaja Najimuddin and Hossain Shahid Suhrawardy were his Cabinet Ministers. Haq government fell in March 1943. After fall of Haq government, Khaja Najimuddin was Chief Minister for a brief period of time. Later AK Fazlul again became Chief Minister.

FAZLUL HUQ'S FIRST CABINET IN 1937



CONTRIBUTION OF FAZLUL HAQ AS PREMIER

Economic and agrarian reform

- **Abolished traditional taxes:** Huq's government passed legislation to abolish the informal taxes that zamindars traditionally imposed on tenants.
- **Reduced debt:** It passed several acts aimed at rural debt relief, including the Bengal Agricultural Debtors' Act (1938) and the Money Lenders' Act (1938).
- **Created debt boards:** The administration established Debt Settlement Boards in all districts to address the issue of rural indebtedness, providing relief to millions of peasants.
- **Reformed tenancy rights:** The Bengal Tenancy (Amendment) Act (1938) suspended rent provisions for a decade and gave tenants the right to transfer their land without paying a transfer fee to the landlords.

Educational advancement

- **Free primary education:** As the cabinet's Education Minister, Huq introduced and passed the Primary Education Bill, which mandated free and compulsory primary education throughout Bengal. This significantly increased access to education, especially for the underprivileged.

1946 PROVINCIAL ELECTION OF BENGAL

- **Affirmative action:** He supported affirmative action for Bengali Muslims and played a role in founding several educational institutions, including Islamia College and Lady Brabourne College in Calcutta.
- **The 1946 Bengal Legislative Assembly election** was held in January 1946 as part of the final British [Indian provincial elections](#) before independence. The election resulted in a decisive victory for the [All-India Muslim League](#), which won 86 seats. Muslim League formed the provincial government in the [Bengal Legislative Assembly](#) under [Prime Minister Huseyn Shaheed Suhrawardy](#). The election played a crucial role in shaping the political future of Bengal, leading to the eventual [partition](#) of the province in 1947.

TWO NATION THEOREY

Muhammad Ali Jinnah explicitly laid out the arguments of the **Two-Nation Theory** in his presidential address to the All-India Muslim League in **Lahore on March 22, 1940**. This speech provided the ideological foundation for the Lahore Resolution (passed the following day on March 23), which formally demanded independent states for Muslims in the northwestern and eastern zones of India.

“We are a nation with our own distinctive culture and civilization, language and literature, art and architecture, names and nomenclatures, sense of values and proportion, legal laws and moral codes, customs and calendar, history and traditions, aptitudes and ambitions, in short we have our own distinctive outlook on life and of life. By all canons of international law, we are a nation.” - Muhammed Ali Jinnah

- The theory emphasizes religious identity as primary determinant of nationhood.
- It asserts that Indian Muslims and Hindus are separate nations as their culture ,social structure,tradition,civilization are separate.
- Two nation theory is driving force for partition of India.

LAHORE RESOLUTION

- Lahore Resolution was adopted by the All India Muslim League in its three general session held in Lahore, Punjab on March 22-24 1940. It called for a separate state for minority Muslim community of India.
- It was moved by the Chief Minister of undivided Bengal Sher-e-Bangla A K Fazlul Haque and seconded by Chowdhury Khaliquzaman. It was later known as Pakistan proposal.

LAHORE RESOLUTION

“Resolved at the Lahore Session of All-India Muslim League held on 22nd-24th March, 1940.

- (1) While approving and endorsing the action taken by the Council and the Working Committee of the All Indian Muslim League as indicated in their resolutions dated the 10th of August, 17th and 18th of September and 22nd of October, 1939, and 3rd February 1940 on the constitutional issues, this Session of the All-Indian Muslim League emphatically reiterates that the scheme of federation embodied in the Government of India Act 1935, is totally unsuited to, and unworkable in the peculiar conditions of this country and is altogether unacceptable to Muslim India.
- (2) Resolved that it is the considered view of this Session of the All India Muslim League that no constitutional plan would be workable in this country or acceptable to Muslims unless it is designed on the following basic principle, namely that geographically contiguous units are demarcated into regions which should be so constituted, with such territorial readjustments as may be necessary, that the areas in which the Muslims are numerically in a majority as in the North-Western and Eastern Zones of India, should be grouped to constitute "Independent States" in which the constituent units shall be autonomous and sovereign.
- (3)

LAHORE RESOLUTION

- (3) That adequate, effective and mandatory safeguards should be specifically provided in the constitution for minorities in these units and in these regions for the protection of their religious, cultural, economic, political, administrative and other rights and interests in consultation with them; and in other parts of India where the Mussalmans are in a minority, adequate, effective and mandatory safeguards shall be specially provided in the constitution for them and other minorities for the protection of their religious, cultural, economic, political, administrative and other rights and interests in consultation with them.
- (4) This Session further authorises the Working Committee to frame a scheme of constitution in accordance with these basic principles, providing for the assumption finally by the respective regions of all powers such as defense, external affairs, communications, customs and such other matters as may be necessary."

LAHORE RESOLUTION

That adequate, effective and mandatory safeguards should be specifically provided in the constitution for minorities in these units and in these regions for the protection of their religious, cultural, economic, political, administrative and other rights and interests in consultation with them; and in other parts of India where the Mussalmans are in a minority, adequate, effective and mandatory safeguards shall be specially provided in the constitution for them and other minorities for the protection of their religious, cultural, economic, political, administrative and other rights and interests in consultation with them.

(4) This Session further authorises the Working Committee to frame a scheme of constitution in accordance with these basic principles, providing for the assumption finally by the respective regions of all powers such as defense, external affairs, communications, customs and such other matters as may be necessary."

AT THE ALL INDIA MUSLIM LEAGUE WORKING COMMITTEE, LAHORE SESSION, MARCH 1940



LAHORE RESOLUTION'S CONTENTS

- It called for grouping together the units and regions where Muslim are in a majority in the North Western and Eastern Zones of British India (such as Punjab, Bengal, Sindh , NWFP, etc) to constitute “independent states” in which constituent units should be autonomous and sovereign. Otherwise it will not be acceptable to the Muslim.
- It focused on effective protection of religious, cultural and economic rights of minorities.
- While the original wording focused on autonomy within British India, the resolution marked a turning point with the Muslim League increasingly aiming for a separate Muslim nation.
- No constitutional plan or revision would be acceptable unless framed on above principles.
- Significance: It laid the groundwork for the partition of India and the creation of Pakistan.
- Amendment of Lahore Resolution: On 9 April 1946, Lahore Resolution was amended by a convention of newly elected Muslim League members of the central and provincial legislature where the word “states” was replaced by word ”state”. Presided over by Mohammed Ali Jinnah, the amendment was moved by Prime Minister of undivided Bengal, Hossain Shahid Suhrawardy, and was approved by the convention. There were questions about its legal validity.

CABINET MISSION PLAN

- A cabinet mission plan was sent to India on 24 March 1946 by the Attlee government to discuss with the Indian political leadership to preserve Indian unity and granting its independence.
- They proposed a three tier administration with a loose federal government and constituent assembly for drafting constitution. Though initially both Congress and Muslim league accepted the proposal, both later rejected it.
- Direct action: Jinnah called upon Muslims to resort to direct action, which resulted in a bloody communal riot taking a toll of 4000 to 6000 lives in Kolkata alone.

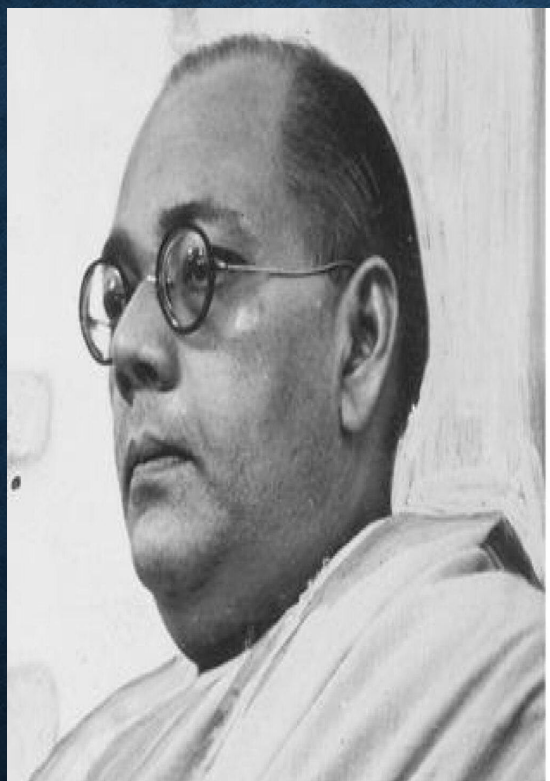
DIRECT ACTION AND MOVE FOR UNITED AND INDEPENDENT BENGAL

- The British Government was now convinced that acceptance of demand for Pakistan is the only solution to ending of anarchy, bloodshed and people's miseries and announced the British plan for partition of India.
- The Indian Independence Act 1947 was promulgated which created two Independent states, India and Pakistan, and thus brought an end of British rule in subcontinent.
- Move for United and Independent Bengal: Before the announcement of the June 3 plan, prominent Muslim and Hindu leaders made desperate attempts to avert partition of Bengal. They include Hossain Shahid Suhrawardy, Chief Minister of Bengal, Abul Hashem, Secretary of Bengal Provincial Muslim League, Sarat Chandra Bose, The elder brother of Subash Chandra Bose and Kiron Sarkar Roy, leader of Congress Parliamentary Board etc. But due to opposition of both central leaders of Congress and Muslim League, this move ended in failure. After the partition, East Bengal became part of Pakistan.

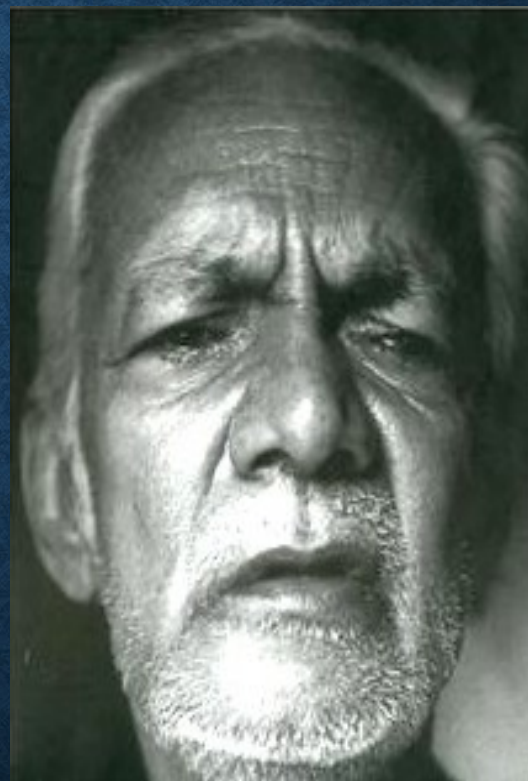
HUSEYN SHAHEED
SUHRAWARDY



SARAT CHANDRA BOSE



ABUL HASHEM



KIRAN SHANKAR
ROY

